

» ASIAN GAMES
PROFILE

A PLACE IN THE SPOTLIGHT AND IN HISTORY

Ancy Sojan spent years wanting people to notice her. Then she broke one of Indian athletics' oldest records, and now everyone will be looking at her at the Asian Games. But she **wants more** — not merely attention but a place in history.

Jonathan Selvaraj

jonathan.selvaraj@thehindu.co.in

Even before she jumped, Ancy Sojan was hard to overlook. Standing at the top of her mark on the synthetic runway at Bhubaneswar's Kalinga Stadium during the Inter-State Athletics Championships a few weeks ago, she cut a striking figure — electric blue acrylic nails, bold eye shadow and lipstick, neon yellow spikes, a stark white headband, large hoop earrings, layered gold chains and jangling bracelets. She really is one of the most distinctive figures in Indian track and field.

And that's precisely how Ancy likes it. She considers herself more than just a long jumper.

"I want people to notice me. I feel like I'm a performer as much as an athlete. Like a magician," she tells *Sportstar*. "I want to get the audience excited. I love every moment I'm on the field. I want the spectators to be amazed by what I'm doing. I love their eyes on me when they're clapping and cheering. I want them to say, 'That's insane. It's better than watching it on video!'"

Her appearance, however, is only part of what makes her stand out. The 25-year-old heads to the Asian Games as one of India's leading medal prospects in athletics. At Bhubaneswar, Ancy smashed one of the longest-standing records in Indian sport, leaping 6.88m to erase Anju Bobby George's 6.83m mark, which had stood since the 2004 Athens Olympics. Her jump is the best in Asia this year, 12cm clear of the next-best mark, and the second-best by an Asian jumper in the last 33 years.

When she steps onto the field at the Paloma Mizuho Stadium in Nagoya, expect Ancy to be blinged out.

The nails, earrings, chains, hair and makeup are not merely accessories. They are part of